wrote, lay ‘mainly through deserts and dry, sandy tracts, where neither springs nor streams are to be found, but only sand everywhere, which is often lifted into the air by the wind, so that people are enveloped in it, and sometimes buried for ever’. Due to the additional dangers of highway bandits, the common folk and the poor often travelled in large caravans, which the Jesuits have described:

> …they choose a captain to lead and command their troop, which often contains two or three thousand persons. That which the Fathers joined consisted of four hundred camels, a hundred carts, and as many horses, and there were besides many poor folk who followed the others on foot…. When travelling by night, in order that the people may not become separated from one another, the drummers lead the way, beating their drums continuously.

The caravans halted along the way wherever wells were to be found, deep wells from which water was raised through carts dragged by bullocks. And so two priests, Father Edouard Leioton and Father Christofle de Vega, arrived at the Mughal court in 1591, somewhat bedraggled, where the Padshah greeted them effusively and lodged them within the palace itself. He urged the Fathers to build a school and promised to send the sons of his courtiers as well as a son and a grandson of his own to learn Portuguese. But less exalted and, perhaps, more realistic than Father Acquaviva, these two Jesuits realized ‘[Akbar] had no intention of making up his mind’ and returned to Goa, ‘having accomplished nothing of what they had intended’.

Salim’s household was growing at this stage and his young son Khusrau began his schooling at the age of four. Abu’l Fazl was appointed to ‘teach him something every day’ while the rest of his education was left to the charge of Abu’l Fazl’s younger brother, Abu’l Khair. In January 1592, a son was born to Jagat Gosain, the daughter of Mota Raja. Akbar handed over his grandchild to the care of his first wife, Ruqaiya Begum. Ruqaiya Begum had remained childless these many decades after marrying Akbar at the age of nine following the death of her father, Hindal. In Lahore, an astrologer had predicted greatness for Jagat Gosain’s as yet unborn son and Ruqaiya Begum had asked of Akbar the gift of raising a future Padshah. Mirza Khurram* as he was named, was raised in Ruqaiya Begum’s care who, Salim later wrote, ‘loved him a thousand times more than if he had been her own’. Salim also noted that Khurram had the exclusive attention of his